CMSC 848N - D1 Annotation Guide

Project: Commitments Hidden in Conversation: Evidence-Grounded Tracking of Conditional Plans and Revisions
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1. Purpose

This guide explains how we will label commitments in meeting transcripts. In a meeting, people may suggest a task, make a plan, promise to do something, or change an earlier promise. We want to keep track of these statements and the words that support them.

We will use public MeetingBank transcripts and some made-up conversations for testing. Everyone on the team should use the same rules. This will help us compare our labels and test our models later.

For each record, we will note the person responsible, the task, any conditions or deadlines, its current status, and the exact text that supports it.

2. Which statements should we label?

We will look for statements about a task someone may do in the future. These can be suggestions, plans, conditional promises, or firm promises. We will also track changes to earlier commitments.

Statement	Label
"We should review the report."	Suggestion
"I'm planning to review the report."	Intention
"I'll review it if the data arrives."	Conditional promise
"I'll review it by Friday."	Firm commitment

A request is not the same as an accepted task. For example, "Can someone write a report?" is a request. It does not prove that anyone agreed to write it. If someone replies, "I'll write it," that reply is a firm commitment.

We may keep a clear task suggestion as a **Proposed** record. We should not count a general meeting instruction, such as "Please turn on your microphone," as a commitment.

3. Commitment force

Commitment force tells us how strongly someone agrees to do a task. We will use the four labels in our proposal.

Label	What it means	Example
Suggestion	Someone proposes a task but does not agree to do it.	"We should meet tomorrow."
Intention	Someone has a plan but does not make a clear promise.	"I plan to finish the report."
Conditional promise	Someone agrees to do a task if a condition is met.	"I'll finish it if I get the data."
Firm commitment	Someone clearly agrees to do a task.	"I'll send it on Friday."

Read the nearby conversation before choosing a label. Do not assume that the person named in a suggestion has accepted the task. Also, "I can write code" only shows an ability. It is not a promise unless the person offers to do a specific task.

4. Commitment status

Status tells us what has happened to the task so far. Force and status are different fields.

Status	What it means
Proposed	A task was suggested, but no one accepted it.
Active	A plan or promise is still in effect.
Revised	An older version was changed.
Completed	Someone says the work was finished, or the meeting gives other clear evidence of completion.
Cancelled	The earlier commitment was withdrawn.
Uncertain	We cannot tell the current status from the available text.

Example:

- "I'll finish the report by Friday." - **Active**.
- "I'll finish it on Monday instead." - Old version: **Revised**. New version: **Active**.
- "I finished the report." - Updated status: **Completed**.

Do not mark a task **Completed** only because the deadline passed. A suggestion that nobody accepted should normally be **Proposed**, not **Active**. A conditional promise can still be **Active** while we wait for the condition.

5. Owner, action, object, and deadline

- **Owner:** Who agreed to do the task. This may be one person or a group.
- **Action:** What they will do, such as *review*, *send*, or *prepare*.
- **Object:** What the action is about, such as a report or a dataset.
- **Deadline:** When the task should be done, if a time was stated.

Example: "I'll review the dataset by Friday."

Field	Value
Owner	The speaker
Action	Review
Object	Dataset
Deadline	Friday

MeetingBank transcripts may not clearly name every speaker. Check the nearby text and other meeting material before assigning a name. If we cannot tell who the owner is, use `unknown` and mark the record as uncertain. If no deadline was given, use `null`. Do not make one up. Keep the date words as they appear in the transcript when possible.

If one statement contains two separate tasks, make two records. For example, "I'll send the files and write the summary" has two actions that can be finished on their own.

6. Conditions (CNF)

A condition is something that must happen before a promise applies. For example, "I'll start testing if the dataset is ready" has the condition **dataset is ready**.

We will store conditions using **CNF**, which stands for *Conjunctive Normal Form*. This is a way to write conditions with **AND** and **OR**:

- **AND** means every group must be true.
- **OR** means at least one choice in a group must be true.

Example 1: Both things must happen.

"I'll test the model if the dataset is ready and the baseline is finished."

```
[
  ["dataset ready"],
  ["baseline finished"]
]
```

Example 2: There is a choice, plus another requirement.

"I'll test the model if the main dataset or backup dataset is ready, and the baseline is finished."

```
[
  ["main dataset ready", "backup dataset ready"],
  ["baseline finished"]
]
```

Each inner list joins choices with **OR**. The outer list joins groups with **AND**. Use `[]` if no condition is stated. Keep the original meaning. Do not assume a condition was met unless the meeting provides evidence.

Be careful with dates in conditions. In "I'll test it if the files arrive by Friday," Friday is when the files must arrive. It is not the deadline to finish testing.

7. Evidence spans

Evidence is the **exact text** that supports a label. As agreed by the team, we will save text spans instead of utterance IDs.

Example: "I'll send the results tomorrow."

Evidence span: `I'll send the results tomorrow.`

Sometimes we need two spans. If one person asks, "Can you review the dataset?" and another says, "Yes, I'll do it tomorrow," the first span names the task and the second shows who accepted it.

Rules:

1. Copy the words exactly. Do not rewrite the quote.
2. Save the source, such as the transcript or meeting minutes.
3. Save the transcript `uid` with the commitment record.
4. Use the shortest span that still proves the label.
5. If the same words appear more than once, add enough nearby text to find the right place.
6. Use more than one span if one quote does not support every detail.

We can link the text to exact places in the transcript later if needed.

8. Changes and revisions

A task can change its owner, action, condition, or deadline. We should keep the old version and add a new one. We should not overwrite the old text.

Example:

- First: "I'll submit the report Friday."
- Later: "I'll submit it Monday instead."

Field	Version 1	Version 2
Commitment ID	C001	C001
Deadline	Friday	Monday
Status	Revised	Active

Both versions have the same `commitment_id`, but different version numbers. The new record should point to the previous version through `revision_of`, such as `C001-v1`. Save the text that explains the change.

Do not link two records just because they discuss the same topic. Only link them when the conversation shows they are about the same task. A progress update, such as "I've started the report," does not count as a revision unless one of the recorded fields or the status changes.

9. Unclear statements and statements to exclude

Do not guess when the text is unclear.

- "I might finish tomorrow." - Not a firm promise. It may be an intention.
- "I think John is working on it." - Does not prove John accepted the task.
- "May we have a staff report?" - A request, not an accepted task.
- "Please use the raise hand feature." - A meeting instruction, not a commitment.
- "I recommend a new policy." - A suggestion, not a promise to make the policy.

Use `unknown` when a value cannot be worked out. Use `null` when something was not stated. Set `uncertainty` to `true` when an important detail is unclear.

In city council meetings, a direction to staff does not always prove that a named staff member accepted the task. Look for evidence of responsibility before naming an owner. A public comment asking for a change is not an active promise by the council.

10. JSON format

Every record should use the same fields. This is a made-up example, not a MeetingBank record.

```
{
  "uid": "SYNTHETIC_EXAMPLE_001",
  "commitment_id": "C001",
  "version": 1,
  "owner": "Speaker A",
  "action": "finish",
  "object": "report",
  "commitment_force": "firm_commitment",
  "conditions_cnf": [],
  "deadline": "Friday",
  "status": "active",
  "evidence": [
    {
      "source": "transcript",
      "text": "I'll finish the report by Friday."
    }
  ],
  "revision_of": null,
  "uncertainty": false
}
```

For real annotations, copy the exact MeetingBank transcript `uid`. For example, one UID in the sample data is `DenverCityCouncil_06192017_17-0498`. Many commitments from one meeting can share the same `uid`, but each separate task needs its own `commitment_id`. A unique record can be identified by its transcript UID, commitment ID, and version number. Do not use `C001` for every task.

11. How we will annotate

1. Read the full meeting or selected section to understand what people mean.
2. Find suggestions, plans, promises, and updates to older commitments.
3. Pick one force label and one status label.
4. Record the owner, action, object, deadline, and CNF conditions.
5. Copy the exact evidence text. Add its source and transcript UID.
6. Check later parts of the meeting for changes or completion.
7. Mark unclear details instead of guessing.

8. Save each record in the same JSON format.

Checking agreement: We should each label the same short sample first. Then we can compare our work, discuss differences, and fix unclear rules before splitting up the rest of the meetings. We should keep a note of difficult cases so that everyone uses the same rule.

12. Full example

The example below is made up. It is not from MeetingBank.

Speaker A: "We should finish the presentation this week."
Speaker B: "I'll prepare the slides if you send me the results."
Speaker A: "I'll send the results by Tuesday."
Speaker A: "Actually, I'll send them Wednesday."
Speaker B: "I'll finish the slides by Friday."
Speaker A: "I sent the results."
Speaker B: "I finished the slides."

ID	Owner	Task	Force	Final status
C001	Unknown	Finish presentation	Suggestion	Proposed
C002	Speaker B	Prepare slides	Conditional promise	Completed
C003	Speaker A	Send results	Firm commitment	Completed

C001: No one agreed to finish the whole presentation, so this stays **Proposed**.

C002: Speaker B agreed to prepare slides if the results were sent. Later, Speaker B gave a Friday deadline and said the slides were finished. Keep the evidence for those updates.

C003: Speaker A first said Tuesday, then changed the deadline to Wednesday. The old deadline must stay in version 1. Later, Speaker A said the results were sent.

A **Completed** label shows what the speakers reported. It does not independently prove the work was done.

13. Final check

Before we use the data for testing, check that:

- The statement is a real task suggestion, plan, promise, or update.
- The force and status fit the words in the transcript.
- The owner, action, object, and deadline are correct.
- CNF conditions keep the meaning of the statement.
- The evidence text matches the source.
- Revisions point to the correct earlier version.
- Transcript UIDs and commitment IDs are correct.
- Unclear details are marked and not guessed.

We should keep the full meetings, including statements with no commitments. This lets us check when a model finds a commitment that is not there.

14. Conclusion

This guide tells us how to label commitments in MeetingBank conversations. It covers task types, status, owners, deadlines, conditions, evidence, revisions, and unclear statements. It also uses CNF for conditions, exact text spans for evidence, and the original transcript UID for each record.

Using the same rules will help our team make consistent labels. We can then use those labels to test whether structured tracking works better than a normal conversation summary.